

# GOBI DESERT

A high, mainly rocky desert that is the largest in Asia

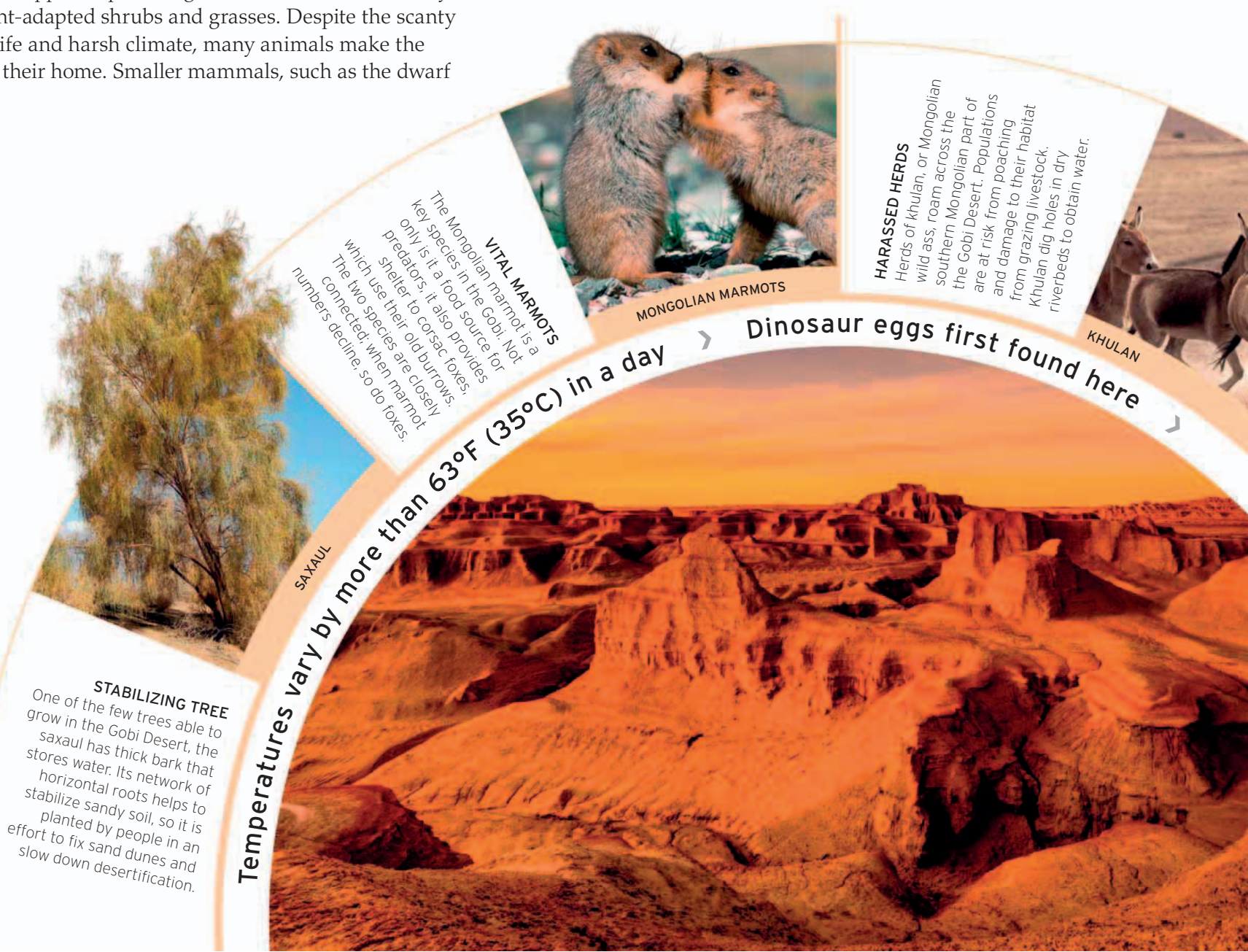
Stretching across part of northern China and into southern Mongolia, the Gobi is the largest desert in Asia and the fifth largest in the world, with an area of around 500,000 sq miles (1.3 million sq km). It is located on a high-altitude plateau, which means that temperatures can fluctuate wildly: in summer they may reach 122°F (50°C) and in winter may fall as low as -40°F (-40°C). Most rain falls during the summer, but annual rainfall diminishes across the region, ranging from around 10 in (250 mm) in the east to just  $\frac{3}{8}$  in (10 mm) in the west.

## Rocky and harsh

The land is primarily rocky rather than sandy. The stony ground supports sparse vegetation in the form of hardy, drought-adapted shrubs and grasses. Despite the scanty plant life and harsh climate, many animals make the desert their home. Smaller mammals, such as the dwarf

hamster and midday gerbil, burrow into sandy ground to escape the searing daytime heat in summer and to hibernate during winter. They benefit the environment by aerating the soil and recycling plant nutrients. Larger animals, such as the Bactrian camel, Mongolian saiga, and Przewalski's wild horse, range far and wide over the desert plains to find sufficient food and water.

The Gobi Desert is expanding by around 1,400 sq miles (3,600 sq km) a year, with the result that devastating dust storms are becoming increasingly frequent. This desertification is also being accelerated by human activities, including deforestation and overgrazing.



**STABILIZING TREE**  
One of the few trees able to grow in the Gobi Desert, the saxaul has thick bark that stores water. Its network of horizontal roots helps to stabilize sandy soil, so it is planted by people in an effort to fix sand dunes and slow down desertification.

SAXAUL

Temperatures vary by more than 63°F (35°C) in a day

**VITAL MARMOTS**  
The Mongolian marmot is a key species in the Gobi. Not only is it a food source for predators, it also provides shelter to corsac foxes. The two species are closely connected: when marmot numbers decline, so do foxes.

MONGOLIAN MARMOTS

## HARASSED HERDS

Herds of khulan, or Mongolian wild ass, roam across the southern Mongolian part of the Gobi Desert. Populations are at risk from poaching and damage to their habitat from grazing livestock. Khulan dig holes in dry riverbeds to obtain water.

KHULAN

Dinosaur eggs first found here